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Former Teachers: Barriers, Incentives and Policy Lessons for Re-entry

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Abstract

[*Abstract — fewer than 150 words, followed by Keywords and JEL codes.*]

Résumé

[*Résumé en français.*]

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Pendiente de escribir (al final de todo).

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To design and evaluate the impact of policies that aim to bring former teachers back to the classroom it is fundamental to have a thorough understanding of the reasons why teachers leave. Moreover, it is crucial to identify the experiences and added value that former teachers can bring back to educational systems if they are successfully reintegrated. This debate is of central importance for governments that are making a wide range of efforts to retain and re-attract former teachers in response to the pressing challenges of an ageing teaching workforce, serious teacher shortages and the rising concerns over teachers' burnout and lack of mentorship (OECD, 2025a; UNESCO, 2024; Madigan and Kim, 2021; OECD, 2025b). This section therefore reviews what is known about why teachers leave, before the paper turns to the policies that have tried to bring them back.

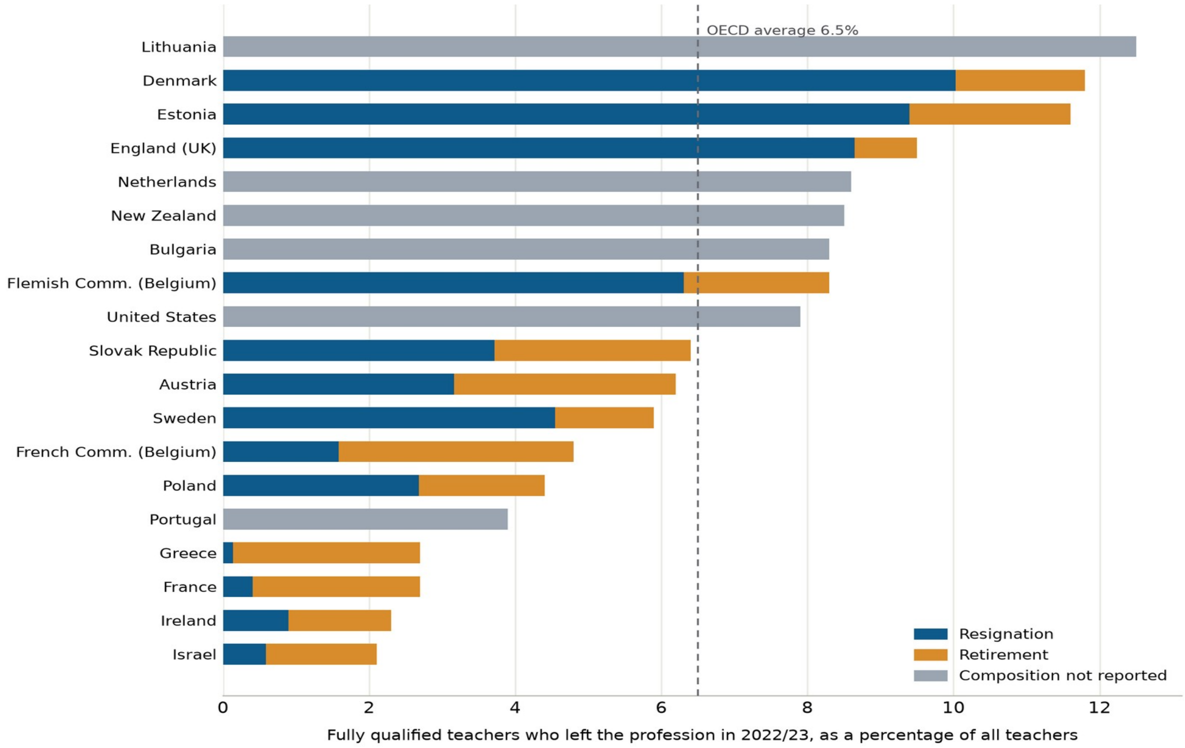
First, we distinguish three main profiles of former teachers: (1) switchers, those who resign from teaching to take up other part-time or full-time employment, (2) leavers, those who withdraw from the labour market, and (3) retired teachers who have reached the end of their working lives. The determinants of leaving and the opportunity cost that each group faces when considering whether to re-enter vary significantly across these profiles. In general terms, for switchers, salary, job satisfaction and working conditions appear to be the central margins; for leavers, household arrangements and flexibility; while for retired teachers, pension rules and re-employment possibilities. However, these institutional factors are highly country-dependent, and a comprehensive description would require a paper of its own. Here we instead develop a general framework that classifies the most common motives for leaving and illustrates them with selected country examples.

2.1 The teacher leaving rate and its evolution

The average teachers leaving rate among the OECD countries was 6.5% in 2023 (OECD, 2025a).[1] However, there are considerable heterogeneities among countries with available data (see Figure 1). In countries with a low leaving rate, close to 2%, such as Israel, Ireland, France and Greece the workforce renews itself through retirement alone, while other countries with a higher proportion of leavers like Lithuania, Denmark or Estonia signal educational systems with a higher number of resignations, raising potential issues with working conditions and teacher retention and forces the system to replace a substantial share of its stock every year.

Figure 1. The teacher leaving rate and its composition, 2022/23

[1] Figure 1 measures departure from the profession, defined as fully qualified teachers who left by resigning or retiring during the reference year. It excludes movement between schools, so these rates are not comparable with turnover statistics, which combine leavers with movers and therefore run higher. The published notes to Table D8.4 apply: primary and lower secondary are combined, and upper secondary excluded, in Denmark; upper secondary is excluded in Israel and upper secondary vocational education in the Netherlands; pre-primary includes early childhood development programmes in Iceland; the reference year is 2021/22 for Denmark, France, England and New Zealand; figures include non-fully qualified teachers in the Netherlands, New Zealand and the Flemish Community of Belgium; and the United States counts as leavers teachers appointed to other positions in the education sector (OECD, 2025a).



Note: Each bar is the share of fully qualified teachers who left the profession in 2022/23. Where the decomposition is reported, the bar splits leavers into those who resigned and those who retired; grey bars report the total rate only. Data cover pre-primary to upper secondary education.

Source: OECD (2025a), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D8.4.

The composition of these departures also differs across systems. In the 19 OECD systems with comparable data, resignations account for 51% of departures, but they exceed 80% in Denmark, England and Estonia, while retirements predominate in France, Greece, Ireland and Israel (OECD, 2025a). Part of this composition reflects the age structure of the workforce, which is ageing in most of the OECD; in Portugal and Greece the share of secondary teachers aged 50 or over has reached 56%, and in Italy 52%, so retirement will drive replacement demand in these systems whatever happens to resignations (OECD, 2025a). For a paper about return, the composition matters as much as the level, because a system losing mid-career resigners and a system losing retirees hold reserves of former teachers with different ages, different licences and different reasons to come back.

The evolution of the leaving rate across time tends to be stable in most of the observed countries. The OECD average rate moved from 6.9% in 2015 to 6.5% in 2023 and most systems present in both years moved by less than a percentage point (OECD, 2025a).[2] Moreover, studies developed in countries with the longest available series confirm this stable trend. In USA, which holds one of the longest-running national series, the rate has oscillated between 5% and 8.5% across three and a half decades of survey waves, has sat near 8% for the last twenty years, and carries no lasting mark from the pandemic increase (NCES, 2024),[3] and similar patterns hold in England, New Zealand, Sweden, Israel, Iceland, Norway and Flanders (Department for Education, 2024a; Education Counts, 2025; Adermon and Laun, 2018; CBS Israel, 2023; Björnsdóttir and Hansen, 2024; Statistics Norway, 2025; Vansteenkiste, 2025).[4]

[2]The two main exceptions are Austria and Estonia, whose rate nearly doubled during the same interval (OECD, 2025a).

[3]The American figures come from the Teacher Follow-up Survey (TFS), which re-interviews one year later a sample of teachers drawn from the Schools and Staffing Survey (SASS) and, since 2015, its successor the National Teacher and Principal Survey (NTPS); the waves are spaced three to five years apart, so the series is discontinuous but covers 1988 to 2022 under a single definition. A continuous annual measure can also be built from the Current Population Survey (CPS), as Harris and Adams (2007) first did for 1992-2001 and Aldeman and Yi (2025) extended to 2015-2024, with results consistent with the survey waves.

[4]For most countries no historical data exists, as such series require longitudinally linked teacher registers. The series that cover only the last decade move both ways, upward in Denmark, Estonia, Lithuania and Korea and downward in Australia and Chile (AE, 2024; Kindsiko, 2023; NŠA, 2025; Ministry of Education Korea, 2023; Buckley and Griselda, 2025; CIAE, 2025).

It is worth noticing that the phenomenon of leaving is not worrying in itself, as a continuous outflow is a common feature of any profession in a dynamic labour market. In fact, even though no comparable benchmark has been published for most OECD countries, the leaving rate of teachers tends to be lower than, or comparable to, that of similar professions where it has been studied. For example, in USA, in the last twenty years the leaving rate for teachers was about the rate at which nurses leave nursing, close to that of accountants and below that of social workers (Aldeman and Yi, 2025), an ordering already visible in the 1990s (Harris and Adams, 2007); in Australia, a study using administrative records finds that the teacher leaving rate was the lowest among 97 occupation groups (Buckley and Griselda, 2025) and in Sweden, register data show that annual exits among teachers, preschool teachers, nurses and police are alike (Adermon and Laun, 2018).

Nevertheless, re-attracting former teachers has become one of the policy margins through which governments are trying to alleviate the current problem of teacher shortages. Although not sufficient to close the gap on its own, it can help reduce and fill vacancies in the short run, especially in the disadvantaged and rural schools where shortages tend to concentrate (UNESCO, 2024; Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2019; Nguyen, Lam and Bruno, 2024). The magnitude of this policy margin depends, in fact, on the baseline leaving and retirement rates, since in countries such as France, Greece, Ireland or Israel, whose low leaving rates are almost solely explained by retirement, its potential is scarce (OECD, 2025a). Nonetheless, beyond short-run relief to shortages, returners and retired teachers can bring benefits of their own, such as experience that spills over to colleagues, mentorship for beginning teachers and tutoring roles with experimental backing (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017; Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024), described in depth in Section 3.

2.2 Determinants of teachers leaving

The reasons why teachers leave the profession have been extensively studied, through self-reported surveys, interviews and, more recently, through administrative records of observed departures. Despite this abundance of evidence, ranking the identified reasons remains difficult, since studies differ in the populations they follow, in the outcomes they measure and in the way motives are grouped. Building on a comprehensive review of this literature and on recent meta-analyses (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024), this paper classifies the reasons into six areas, defined by the domain to which each belongs and by the authority with the capacity to intervene in it (Table 1).

Table 1. Reasons for leaving teaching, by area

Area	Reasons
Professional factors	Loss of professional purpose; limited autonomy over the work; professional standing; exposure to parental complaint and legal risk
Working conditions	Hours and total workload; pupil behaviour and classroom discipline; administrative and documentation demands; limited access to reduced hours; burnout and exhaustion
Organisational factors	School leadership; collegial support and team structure
Accountability and regulation	External inspection and its consequences; certification and licensing requirements
Financial factors	Salary relative to outside options; pension design and its timing incentives; contract insecurity
Personal and life-course factors	Family formation and care; childbirth; health and incapacity; relocation and a partner's circumstances; retirement and career stage

Source: Authors' elaboration on the literature reviewed in this section.

These six areas group motives that range from the meaning teachers attach to their work to the rules under which they are employed, and the evidence does not weigh them equally. In the meta-analyses that pool the correlates of observed departure, the factors attached to the school carry more weight than the personal characteristics of the teacher, and teachers in schools with better working conditions face roughly half the odds of leaving, while class size, the variable public debate returns to most readily, shows no association at all (Nguyen et al., 2020). The strength of many of these associations also changes with the outcome measured, since a factor that predicts the intention to leave does not necessarily predict the departure itself (Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024). The discussion that follows walks through the six areas in the order of Table 1, highlighting how they relate to each other.

First, professional factors group the motives related to the purpose, autonomy and standing of the work. Asked in their own words, the reason leavers name most often is the loss of commitment to the work itself. In Finland, a longitudinal survey that followed teachers over five years found a lack of professional commitment named ahead of workload and interpersonal difficulty among those declaring an intention to leave, far more often by men, while women cited workload and conflicts (Räsänen et al., 2020).[5] The Finnish setting makes this reading unusually clean, since Finnish teachers enjoy wide autonomy and adequate pay, so the remaining complaint concerns the purpose of the work. Professional standing, and the exposure that accompanies its loss, pushes departures in some systems with a force the aggregate statistics only partly capture. In Korea, early retirements of teachers rose from 869 in 2005 to 6 594 in 2021, a rise official research attributes above all to the infringement of teachers' rights, including exposure to parental complaint and legal action (KEDI, 2023).[6] The legislature treated the diagnosis as accurate, amending four statutes on the protection of teachers' educational activities in September 2023 (Republic of Korea, 2023), although no evaluation yet connects the reform to retention. These are also the least measured motives of the six, since they rest almost entirely on what teachers themselves report.

Secondly, another commonly cited reason, very present in the public debate, is working conditions. Workload is the most declared motive nearly everywhere the question is asked. Among Dutch teachers who had recently left, 47% named workload, stress and burden ahead of every other category (Van Casteren et al., 2023), and workload ranks first among Swedish leavers and second among Australian ones (Statistics Sweden, 2023; Brandenburg et al., 2024). What predicts departure, however, is not what the declarations emphasise. In England, TALIS 2018 responses were linked to the administrative register of the school workforce to study the effective determinants of departure, and not only the declared ones, by observing who had left the profession a year after answering the survey.[7] Experienced teachers who work in schools with worse discipline leave more, and the magnitude is considerable, since a one-standard-deviation improvement in the school's discipline climate is associated with a halving of the annual probability of leaving the profession, while self-reported working hours, the motive most cited in surveys, do not predict departure robustly (Sims and Jerrim, 2020). The discipline measure captures whether rules are applied consistently, whether disruption is contained and whether teachers are free of intimidation, which suggests that the load that expels is not the volume of work but the conditions under which it must be done. This gap between what teachers state and what their behaviour reveals recurs throughout this section and is examined in Section 2.3.

How much of that load a teacher can lawfully shed varies enormously between systems, and the variation changes what the declaration means. A Dutch employer must grant a request for fewer hours unless a weighty business interest prevents it, and two thirds of Dutch lower-secondary teachers work part-time; Japanese teachers, who hold no such entitlement, are at 7% (OECD, 2025c); an English teacher holds a right to ask that a school may refuse on eight statutory grounds (United Kingdom, 1996).[8] Where hours

[5] The survey followed Finnish comprehensive-school teachers over five years and measured turnover intentions and their stated reasons, not observed exits. About half of respondents reported turnover intentions at some point, and the reason a teacher gave was unstable, since fewer than half of those with persistent intentions named the same factor five years apart.

[6] The KEDI series reached this review through official Korean reporting; the full bibliographic details of the underlying survey remain to be completed before publication.

[7] TALIS is the OECD's international survey of teachers and school leaders in primary and lower secondary education. In its 2018 round, 73% of surveyed English teachers consented to having their responses linked to the School Workforce Census, the annual administrative register of the staff of England's state-funded schools, and the matching produced 2 684 linked records at a match rate of 84%. The analysis, commissioned by the Department for Education, is Sims and Jerrim (2020), available at https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/talis-2018-teacher-working-conditions-turnover-and-attrition.

[8] The Dutch entitlement rests on the Wet flexibel werken, under which a request left unanswered past the statutory deadline is deemed granted. The English right to request flexible working sits in Part 8A of the Employment Rights Act 1996, and the eight permissible grounds of refusal include the burden of additional costs and the inability to reorganise work among existing staff.

can be reduced, an overloaded teacher can buy relief without resigning; where they cannot, the same complaint has only one margin left. Reduced hours are also the margin through which family responsibilities and teaching are reconciled, which ties this area to the personal factors examined below. No study yet estimates what part-time access does to teacher exit, which leaves one of the most widespread working-conditions instruments without an evaluated effect.

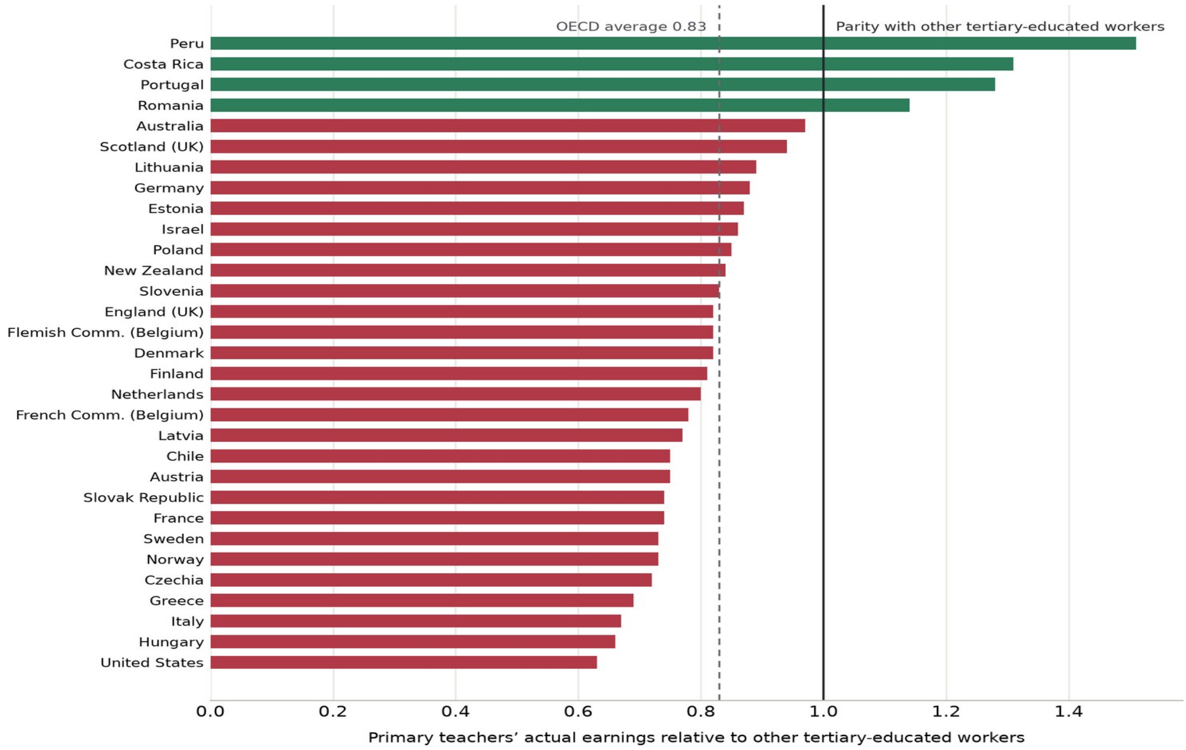
Additionally, organisational factors play a more important role than commonly believed. School leadership is the reason most often associated with departure across this literature and among the hardest to isolate, because head teachers are not assigned to schools at random, schools with better heads differ in pupils, resources and staff, and teachers who choose to stay tend to rate their head more favourably. Among the contextual factors measured in New York City, teachers' perceptions of the school administration carry the greatest influence on retention decisions (Boyd et al., 2011), and panel evidence that follows change within the same school over time, where improvements in leadership, expectations and safety were accompanied by falling turnover, is the closest the field has come to separating the leadership effect from the school around it (Kraft, Marinell and Shen-Wei Yee, 2016). Leadership also connects this area to the previous one, since the discipline climate that predicts departure in England is largely a product of how a school is run. The other organisational lever is mentoring. Young teachers are more likely to remain in their school if they are mentored by an older teacher at the start of their career; in observational research, those who receive mentoring leave less often, with the odds of departure at about three quarters of those of unmentored colleagues (Nguyen et al., 2020), and England's evaluation of the Early Career Framework, which entitles every new teacher to two years of structured mentoring, estimated 4.4 additional percentage points of retention in the original school after two years (Walker et al., 2024).

Not surprisingly, how demanding the accountability and regulation regime is also affects the leaving rate. External inspection is the clearest case, and England, which holds both a published inspection judgement and a linked workforce census, allows the declared and the observed weight of this motive to be compared, as 30% of surveyed teachers report having considered leaving after their last inspection (Perryman et al., 2025), whereas an inadequate judgement raises observed turnover by 3.4 percentage points, about a quarter of its average level, and an outstanding one does not reduce it (Sims, 2016). The gap between the two numbers repeats the pattern already seen with workload. Regulation also matters at the point of return, since certificates lapse with time out of the classroom and the cost of restoring them becomes part of any decision to come back, a margin that reappears in Section 2.4 and in Section 3.

The economic incentives also play a key role and are probably the most studied factor of the six, since pay and pensions are set centrally and their reforms create discontinuities that research can exploit. Whether to keep teaching is a decision each teacher takes by comparing what the post offers with the best that same person could obtain outside it. That outside option differs with the subject taught, the qualification held and the local labour market, which is why a single pay scale produces very different exit rates across subjects and regions, and why the shortages most systems report are shortages of physics, mathematics and computing teachers before they are shortages of teachers in general. Where pay has been tested causally, money retains. A Norwegian premium of about 10% for schools with recruitment difficulties cut voluntary quits by around a third of their level (Falch, 2011); English payments of GBP 2 000 a year after tax made eligible mathematics and physics teachers 23% less likely to leave (Sims and Benhenda, 2022); a North Carolina bonus for mathematics, science and special-education teachers in high-poverty schools lowered turnover in the target group by about 17% (Clotfelter et al., 2008). The reductions run from 9% to 23% across these programmes, though the effect has lasted only as long as the payment itself (See et al., 2020). Behind those margins sits the level. In most OECD countries primary teachers earn less than the average tertiary-educated worker, at 83% of that benchmark on average, from 63% in the United States to 128% in Portugal (Figure 2).[9]

[9]Indicator D3 compares the average serving teacher's salary with the earnings of the average tertiary-educated worker. It measures the standing of the occupation, not the outside option of any individual teacher, and its methodological notes warn that it divides a mean teacher salary by a median comparator figure in some countries, a difference worth up to 14% where both can be computed (OECD, 2025d).

Figure 2. Primary teachers earn less than other tertiary-educated workers in most countries



Note: Ratio of the annual average actual salary of full-time primary teachers in public institutions, including bonuses and allowances, to the earnings of full-time, full-year workers with tertiary education aged 25 to 64. Countries absent from the chart do not report the series. Data refer to 2024 or the nearest available year.

Source: OECD (2025d), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D3.2.

Salary trajectories after leaving differ systematically by destination, and the distinction reads directly on the outside option. Those who remain within the education sector, the majority everywhere this has been measured, experience small salary changes; those who abandon the sector face a far more dispersed distribution of outcomes, with thick tails at both ends, and the upper tail is concentrated among men and among shortage specialisations. United States tax records show mean earnings still slightly below pre-exit teaching pay eight years after departure, with about one fifth of leavers not employed at all, the bottom quartile of employed leavers under USD 20 000 a year and the top quartile out-earning nearly all of those who stayed (Brummet et al., 2024).[10] Florida records give the same shape by destination, with the ratio of the ninetieth to the fiftieth percentile of earnings rising from 1.3 to 1.8 among leavers to other industries and unchanged among those who moved within the sector (Chingos and West, 2012), and the earlier state studies of Georgia and Missouri concluded that very few exiting teachers took jobs paying more than their teaching salaries (Scafidi, Sjoquist and Stinebrickner, 2006; Podgursky, Monroe and Watson, 2004). Danish register data and Australian panel data agree in direction, at around 6% below previous pay (ROCKWOOL Fonden, 2025; Cuervo and Vera-Toscano, 2025). England is the partial exception, where leavers out-earn their own last teaching salary by 7% after one year and 21% after ten, and still fall behind comparable teachers who stayed, whose earnings grew 37% over the same decade (Worth and McLean, 2022).

Pay is only half of the financial area. In most pension schemes covering teachers, retiring before the age the rules set reduces the pension, and retiring later barely increases it, so teacher retirements cluster around that age, which is a parameter of the regulation and not of individual preferences. The mechanism is the shape of accrual. Pension wealth does not accumulate at the same pace across a career;

[10] The study links the human-resources records of a large urban school district over twelve years of leavers to federal tax records held at the United States Census Bureau, and is the only United States evidence that observes leavers who disappear from employer records entirely, which is why its mean sits below studies that condition on employment.

in defined-benefit schemes it grows slowly through most of the career, very fast in the years immediately before the full-pension age, and hardly at all afterwards, so that one more year of work can be worth a great deal at 54 and almost nothing at 60 (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009). The profile is not particular to the United States. Accrual concentrated around rule-set ages is documented in the civil-service teacher schemes of Germany, France, Spain, Portugal and Austria and in the legacy schemes of England and Ontario, while notional and funded defined-contribution systems, as in Sweden, Australia and post-reform Norway, are close to actuarially neutral and spread retirements accordingly (OECD, 2025e).[11] Teachers anticipate these incentives, and retirements concentrate at the ages from which retiring stops being penalised; structural estimates on administrative records reproduce the observed retirement spikes as forward-looking responses to the rules (Ni and Podgursky, 2016). The retirement peaks visible in Figure 1 are therefore partly a product of design.

When early retirement carries a pension reduction, teachers postpone it. France's 2003 reform priced early claiming for public servants, and retirement at ages 60 and 61 among secondary teachers fell by around 9 percentage points in the study that exploits the reform's discontinuity (Baraton, Beffy and Fougère, 2011); Dutch public employees born after a cut-off date that lowered pension wealth postponed their expected retirement (Montizaan, Cörvers and de Grip, 2010). Germany offers the same picture descriptively. After deductions of up to 10.8% were introduced in 2001 for incapacity retirement before the age of 63, the share of teacher retirements taken on incapacity grounds fell from 64% to 28% within three years, and the mean retirement age of teachers rose by three years to 62 (Statistisches Bundesamt, 2005), although the series records a coincidence in time with the reform and not an estimated effect.

From an economic perspective, a teacher's lifetime income has two parts, the salary collected while working and the pension collected after retirement. The future pension is an incentive to remain in teaching only to the extent that the teacher values it today, and that valuation and the cost of funding the promise need not coincide. If teachers heavily discount income that lies decades ahead, the state pays dearly for an instrument that retains little, and the same money would retain more if paid as current salary. The evidence leaves the valuation open. When Illinois teachers were offered the chance to buy additional pension rights at a stated price, their willingness to pay was about 20 cents per dollar of present value (Fitzpatrick, 2015), while following the same cohort to retirement points to a much higher valuation (Ni, Podgursky and Wang, 2022).[12] What the quasi-experimental record does establish is that pension generosity retains selectively. Enhancements and cuts to deferred benefits move separations little among younger public employees, and teachers have been the least responsive occupation studied (Koedel and Xiang, 2017; Quinby and Wettstein, 2021), which is consistent with deferred pay binding those close to the accrual spike and doing little, per unit of cost, for the early-career teachers among whom attrition is highest.

Finally, personal and life-course factors also drive a substantial part of departures, and the birth of a child is one of the main reasons female teachers leave. In England, where the workforce census can follow teachers after maternity leave, between 17% and 20% of those who return leave the profession within a year, double the rate of comparable teachers, and women aged 30 to 39 form the largest group among those who leave (Department for Education, 2023).[13] Structural modelling attributes much of the fall in teachers' labour-force participation after certification to marriage and fertility, and two thirds of exiting female teachers left the labour market altogether (Stinebrickner, 2001; Stinebrickner, 2002). Where the law makes hours adjustable, the same event shows up inside the profession instead of at its exit, as in Germany, where 43% of teachers work part-time, or the Netherlands, where about a quarter of female

[11] Causal evidence that teacher retirement timing responds to these incentives exists for the United States, France and the Netherlands, with Germany documented descriptively; for the remaining systems the scheme parameters are documented but the behavioural response is not.

[12] The two estimates bracket the question without resolving it. The willingness-to-pay figure comes from take-up of a real upgrade offer priced against present value; the later study follows the same cohort to retirement and finds that most teachers eventually bought the upgrade and that decliners faced a negative net return given their retirement timing, which implies a valuation far above 20 cents.

[13] The maternity-return figures are Department for Education ad hoc statistics for 2016-2019 reported to Parliament; the original statistical release should be verified before publication. In 2022/23, women aged 30 to 39 leaving state-funded schools in England numbered over 9 000, against roughly 3 400 men of the same age.

primary teachers work full-time (Destatis, 2024; CBS, 2023). A causal estimate of the effect of childbirth on teacher exit and return does not yet exist in any OECD system, and the gap is immediate for a paper about re-entry, because a teacher on a career break and a teacher permanently gone cannot at present be told apart in the data.

The law around that event varies as much as the part-time rules already discussed. A Spanish teacher on a permanent public contract has nineteen weeks of paid leave and may take up to three years of childcare leave per child, the first two with her post reserved (Government of Spain, 2015; Government of Spain, 2025); a teacher in the United States is guaranteed twelve unpaid weeks under federal law, and fewer than one in five large districts pay parental leave (United States, 2013; National Council on Teacher Quality, 2026).[14] In the Spanish design, childbirth interrupts a teaching career without ending it, and the returner population is by construction on leave; in the American design, the same event forces an exit that the system then has to reverse through re-employment. This area also frames the career as a whole. Departure is most frequent in the first years of teaching, falls through mid-career and rises again as retirement approaches, a profile documented across the 46 studies of an early systematic review (Guarino, Santibañez and Daley, 2006). The early peak reflects sorting, as entrants discover whether the job matches what they trained for; the late peak reflects the pension rules just examined; between the two sits the long stretch of stable mid-career service where most of the potential returner population accumulates.

Read together, the six areas do not weigh equally, and their imbalance is itself a finding. The school-attached factors, conditions, leadership and pupil behaviour, carry the most weight in observed departures; the financial ones are the best identified and bind most strongly at particular ages; the professional and family motives dominate what teachers say and remain the hardest to verify. Nor does the ranking settle what policy should do about departure, since who leaves matters as much as how many. Where low-performing teachers were induced to leave, their replacements raised student achievement by 0.21 standard deviations in mathematics and 0.14 in reading (Adnot et al., 2017), while high turnover harms achievement where it clusters, in disadvantaged schools most of all (Ronfeldt, Loeb and Wyckoff, 2013). For re-entry policy, each area points to the authority able to act on it, and Section 3 orders the policies accordingly.

2.3 Stated and revealed preferences

The gaps found throughout the previous section share a common structure, the one expected between stated and revealed preferences (Samuelson, 1938). Teachers who leave declare workload and personal circumstances as their principal motives and place salary in the middle of the list. Teachers who are considering leaving place salary at or near the top. Observed decisions respond strongly to salary variation. Among American leavers surveyed after departure, higher pay is the fourth most-cited main reason, at 9.5%, behind retirement, personal life and another job (NCES, 2024); among serving teachers considering departure it is second, at 60% (Doan et al., 2023).[15] English leavers cite pay at 25% to 34% against 74% to 84% for workload (Department for Education, 2024b), and Dutch leavers rank it sixth at 22% (Van Casteren et al., 2023). Set against those declarations, across twelve discrete-choice experiments in eight countries a 10% pay increase raises the probability of choosing a post by 5 to 12 percentage points (Sims, Lowes-Belk and Routledge, 2026), and Dutch part-time teachers require a 23% increase in net hourly pay before accepting a full-time post (Somers et al., 2024a). The three measurements are not in contradiction; they measure the narrative a person gives, the plan a person holds and the choice a person makes, and pay weighs least in the first and most in the last. The contrast between stated and revealed preferences is therefore drawn in this paper on realised exits, and not on plans.

[14] The Spanish provisions are Article 49 (paid leave, extended to nineteen weeks in 2025) and Article 89.4 (childcare leave with post reservation) of the consolidated public-employment statute; the American floor is the Family and Medical Leave Act, whose school-specific regulations allow a district to keep a teacher on leave until the end of a term in defined circumstances.

[15] The two American sources measure different populations with different instruments. The National Center for Education Statistics figure comes from the Teacher Follow-up Survey of 2021-22 former teachers, who choose one main reason; the 60% figure comes from the RAND State of the American Teacher survey of serving teachers, who select all reasons for considering departure, among whom pay ranks first for early-career and Black teachers. A Michigan survey of intending leavers likewise places pay at the top jointly with workload, which illustrates how intention surveys and leaver surveys order the same motives differently.

Many more teachers say they will leave than do. Where intention and behaviour have been measured on the same people, one leaves for every three or four who declare the intention. In a nationally representative American survey of 102 970 teachers linked to the following year's behaviour, 32.5% of those intending to leave as soon as possible had left a year later, against 6.8% of everyone else, and two thirds of them were still teaching (Nguyen et al., 2025).[16] Intention data still have a use, since they locate dissatisfaction across countries and school types, but they do not forecast supply. The 17% of teachers across TALIS systems who intend to leave within five years cannot for that reason be read against the 6.5% annual rate of departure; the two measure different things (OECD, 2025b; OECD, 2025a).

Intention data retain one comparative advantage all the same. Although only one in three or four of those declaring an intention actually leaves, TALIS collects, for every participating system, both the intention to leave and a wide set of declared factors, from sources of stress to satisfaction with pay and autonomy, so the association between motives and intended departure can be read on a single questionnaire across many systems, provided the result is treated as an upper bound on realised exits (OECD, 2025b).

2.4 Destinations after leaving

Most of those who leave teaching keep working in the education sector, and former teachers are therefore locatable through the records of employers and regulators. In the United States, linked tax records show more than half of leavers still in education broadly defined and about one fifth out of the labour force (Brummet et al., 2024); the first-year composition is similar in Australia, where over two fifths of leavers hold jobs in school education or in other education, health and social assistance work (Cuervo and Vera-Toscano, 2025), and most English leavers who do not retire take education-sector jobs (Worth, Bamford and Durbin, 2015). The modern former teacher is usually still employed, often nearby, and reachable through the same administrative systems that already pay or license them.

Box 2.1. Where American leavers go

The United States offers the most complete accounting of destinations, because district records can be linked to federal tax data. Followed for eight years after departure, more than half of leavers remain in education in a broad sense, in other districts, private schools or education-adjacent work; about one fifth hold no employment at all; and fewer than a quarter work outside education altogether, the group in which earnings disperse most (Brummet et al., 2024). [Figure to be inserted: destinations of United States leavers.]

The population of former teachers is large wherever it has been counted, and the gross count overstates the usable reserve, which discounts expired certificates and specialisations without vacancies. Michigan holds 141 810 certified teachers, of whom 61 252 do not teach in a public school, and half of those hold expired certificates, against 6% of active teachers (Lindsay, Gnedko-Berry and Wan, 2021); the Netherlands counts some 62 000 qualified teachers outside education, four times its measured secondary shortage (Somers et al., 2024b).[17] What a return offer can expect depends on why each person left. In Scotland, most of the teachers interviewed at length had left after an accumulation of pressures with no single trigger, and with their vocational commitment intact (Hulme et al., 2026), which suggests that the reserve contains people for whom the question is the conditions of a return and people for whom it is closed. It is to that population, and to the instruments aimed at it, that the next section turns.

[16] The correlation between stated intention and observed departure in the same data is 0.15.

[17] The Michigan count refers to certificates in force in 2018-19; the Dutch estimate defines the silent reserve as qualified teachers below retirement age employed outside education altogether.

3. The policies

My proposed labeling/characterization of initiatives and policies is the following:

Regulatory / legal
Financial incentives
Information & nudges
Support & training
Flexible positions
Flexible re-certification

4. Conclusions

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